Geometry of Despair: Venn Diagram

By David James Poissant

Every Wednesday, after dinner, Lisa and I fight the traffic to the nondenominational church across town. Here, for an hour, a dozen of us sit in a circle telling our same sad stories. Each week, Pam, our counselor, reminds us that it isn't a competition, that the goal of group therapy is not to outdo each. Hardship, she assures us, cannot be measured. But validation awaits those who tell the best stories.

What it comes down to is the following equation: If a train leaves Chicago at 60 miles an hour and another train leaves Atlanta at 80 miles an hour, when they both collide in Kentucky and everybody's babies die, who gets to be the saddest?

INTRODUCTION

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Every Wednesday [for an entire year] . . . There's Dot and Drew, whose son was decapitated when he tried to drive home after too many tallboys. Granted, a tragedy, but at least they had him for 18 years. And, hey, if they'd been better parents, who knows?

One week, a weepy, mascara-stained wreck of a woman stops by. She introduces herself as Jenna, tells us her story, and, for a moment, we have a winner. Her 3-month-old dies without explanation, and it isn't until a year later, that her husband admits to shaking the baby. In this way, three becomes two, then one.

Still, my wife says, it's not the same. Jenna has someone she gets to be mad at. Jenna has somebody she can blame. It's like when you're in grade school, Lisa says, and your friend gives you a present, then takes the gift back, only, here, it's God who's the Indian giver.

With SIDS, the despair isn't tied to regret or what-ifs or whose fault. With sudden infant death syndrome, the only thing you want to know--after you wake with the shock that you slept through the night, after you sit up and consider the silence; after you swallow your paranoia and go to the baby, only to feel the warm rush of panic flooding your chest, after the

touching, the holding, the shouting, the signing, right here, on the dotted line--after it all, the only thing you want to know is why?

It's a question we ask each Wednesday, a question for which there is no answer.

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The divorce rate for a couple who loses an infant child is 75 percent. Most couples split up inside of a year. Our own one-year mark [is now] just two weeks away, I've decided that Lisa and I are no exception. It's not that we've stopped loving each other, only that every time I look into Lisa's eyes, all I see is my little girl. The same goes for Lisa. The miracle, really, is that we've lasted as long as we have.

Lying in bed one tired Wednesday night after group, we consider the possibility of separating. It isn't the first time the subject's come up. Lisa hasn't bothered to wash her face before bed, and her eyes are still red and puffy. "You don't have to go, you know," she says. She takes my hand to show me she's taking me seriously, but I can tell she's exhausted, drained by the meeting. I can't face Lisa when she is crying. But, on

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Wednesday nights, with no emotion left, we can talk about my leaving like strangers discussing the weather.

"Actually," I say, "I kind of think I do."

"We could figure something out."

"No. Not really. You know that. Don't you?" I rub the back of her hand with my thumb.

"I'm just saying," Lisa says. "There's got to be a solution."

"But there isn't," I say. "What happened, it's going to haunt us as long as we're together."

"Maybe if we keep going to group ... " Lisa's voice cracks. She sinks deeper into the covers, lets go of my hand. Beside me, she suddenly looks very small.

"I'd still go with you," I say. "I'm not saying we should to get divorced. I'm just suggesting some time apart, a trial separation."

"Right. Because those always have such happy endings . . . You need time apart," she says. "Not me. You. You don't know what I need."

"What do you need?"

"I don't know," she says.

Both of us are silent for a minute. When I speak again, I choose my words with care. I say: "I just think

that maybe I need to leave for a while, you know? Get some perspective. Figure things out."

Lisa sits up. She looks [at] me, and her eyes dance with anger. "Do you ever stop long enough to hear yourself speak?" she says. "Do you even listen to the crap that comes out of your mouth? Why can't you get this through your thick skull? There's nothing to figure out. You keep saying you want to figure stuff out, but what does that mean? It's not an equation, Richard. It doesn't balance on both sides. No matter how many ways you try to solve for X, it won't come out even. You'll wind up with less than you started with, every time."

I don't want to be the one to cry first, but, suddenly, I am.

"You can't escape what's happened by leaving this house," Lisa says. "The only thing you escape by leaving here is me."

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Have you ever been to a baby's funeral? There's an absurdity to the pageantry: the miniature casket, the floral arrangements done up in pastels. I don't remember anything the minister said. I only remember I couldn't breathe.

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Friends and relatives followed us home after the funeral. "You shouldn't be alone right now," everyone said. Lisa nodded, wearing a smile I'd never seen before and haven't seen since. She was determined to do whatever everyone thought was best.

In the midst of all this, Lisa and I started fighting. I wanted to be left alone. Lisa liked the company. I couldn't tell you what was said, but the argument escalated quickly, our voices competing with the din of the crowded living room. I screamed something. Lisa screamed something back. And then ours were the only voices left. In my mind, I was a bird with a broken wing, the neighborhood cats closing in.

"Please," I said. "Go away. Our baby just died. Please. Leave us alone."

"Why do you care?" Lisa snapped. "You never wanted her anyway. It's your fault! You didn't want her and she died!" Lisa collapsed into me, pressed her face to my chest, heaving. And, in that moment, I hated my wife. Her very touch repulsed me.

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It's true though, what Lisa said. The pregnancy was not what people now call "planned," and I hadn't

wanted the baby, not at first. The high school is where we met, where I'd been teaching geometry to teenagers for 10 years. Lisa was the new biology instructor in town.

A month after the wedding, Lisa gave me the news. "Well, aren't you excited?"

Words tumbled around in my brain, all the words I knew I should say, the words you use for just such an occasion, but none found their way to my tongue.

"Fine," Lisa said.

Within days, though, my attitude changed. Soon enough, Lisa could see that I wanted the baby just as much as she did. Sure we had intended to wait a little longer, but so what? We were having a baby! I was going to be a father! Our daughter was born in June and we named her just that: June.

It was only after June died in July that the subject of my initial reluctance resurfaced. Lisa never mentioned it again, not after the outburst following the funeral, but it stayed with us, a green cloud hanging low in the house. When we fought, I felt her holding back, and, with every argument, I waited--am waiting still--for her to throw the accusation back in my face, as though

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death were a thing I wished upon our daughter when she was still in the womb.

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I was the one who discovered June. It's why I don't sleep well at night, why morning sends me rocketing to the cradle that's no longer there, that, for weeks, held only a pillow, a pacifier, a yellow stuffed duck.

At first, Lisa wouldn't let me disassemble the cradle. So, one Saturday, when I knew she would be out for a while, I took the thing apart, packed the pieces into a box, labeled the cardboard with black Magic Marker, and carried the box up to the attic. When Lisa got home, [she] stopped, surveyed the room, and, for the longest time, stood very still.

"What's wrong," I asked, knowing full well the thing Lisa was missing.

"Nothing," she said.

Like everything else, it was easier to say nothing at all.

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[This] Wednesday, we go to group as usual. It is to be my last night with Lisa. By morning, I've decided, I will be gone.

Pam opens with the usual prayer, the one that concludes with our standard chant: "Lord, grant us peace. Help us rejoice in the hope of your glory. And help us rejoice in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance, perseverance character, and character the hope that springs eternal. Amen."

Pam asks who would like to share, and, immediately, Lisa raises her hand. I know that she is going to tell everyone that tomorrow marks the one-year anniversary of June's death.

Before I know what I'm doing, I stand. My chair tips back, falls to the floor behind me. I bellow: "Don't you get it? You people are so superstitious! You keep looking for reasons and meaning and signs! But the truth is, it doesn't mean anything! None of it means anything! There's no good reason for any of it. It's all just coincidence and bad luck and chance. Our kids are dead. We're not special. We're just unfortunate."

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When I look up, Pam is in front of me. She places a hand on my shoulder, and, without meaning to, I fall to my knees.

"You're angry," Pam says. "But, I promise you, it gets easier. God will not give you more than you can bear."

A hand touches my face and I can tell, without looking, that it's Lisa's. The words are lost on me. But the sense of touch stays with me, even after I've left the church.

[That night] I fall right to sleep. It's not the same sleep as the last few hundred nights, that anxious, unchained sleep, so that night finds me in the attic, alone with the toys and the dresses and the little white shoes. Instead, nodding off, I feel something holding me down, heavy as light, silent as summer rain. It's like leaving purgatory at last, like sleeping the quiet sleep of the dead.

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The next morning, I wake, look at the clock. It's nearly 9, impossible, now, to make my escape without causing a scene. I head downstairs, drawn by the smell of coffee. I pause on the bottom step, consider, again,

the notion of leaving just to see what I will feel. But, at the thought, I feel neither sorrow nor relief, only the sweet tug of indecision.

In the kitchen, Lisa stands at the window. She is still in her bathrobe, a mug of coffee in one hand, the curve of her neck cradled in the other.

"Coffee?" Lisa says.

"Yes," I say, "please. Thank you."

Lisa moves to the cupboard, the stove, returns with a second cup. I reach out and the mug is hot in my hand. I twist the mug around, hold it by the handle.

"Lisa, I don't want to go." When I hear myself say it, I know it is true. Because it would be the easiest thing in the world to walk out that door. Because, in the end, it doesn't matter which one of us has suffered most, or what has been said, or how we've chosen to manage our sadness.

How do you graph the geometry of despair? Is sorrow, at its heart, a line or a circle? And what is a circle but a line that can't let go? Each of us charts our own path across sadness. Somehow, Lisa and I have met in the middle. At its midpoint, grief is a desert, and it's a long hike back to the basin. I take Lisa into my arms.

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"Stay," she says. And it is as if there was never the need for a choice. "Stay," she says, and I do.

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